

Media and Message Coaching

Project C

October 2025

Today's roadmap

- Why earned media?
- Pitch perfect pitching
- Developing messaging and talking points
- Interview tips and tricks
- Q&A

Pitching Tips

Formats & What to Highlight

→ How to tailor your pitch for radio, podcasts, broadcast (local & national), and live stages.

Sample One-Liners

→ Ready-to-use examples that make your pitch clear and compelling.

Beyond the Inbox

→ Smarter ways to reach producers & organizers — why DMs and direct contact work.

Format	What to Highlight in Pitch	Why it Works
Radio Hit	Quick, sharp expertise on one issue; ability to explain clearly in soundbites.	Radio needs fast, engaging voices who can distill complex topics in minutes.
Podcast (Long-Form)	Depth of knowledge, unique perspective, personal anecdotes or reporting journey.	Podcasts thrive on narrative, detail, and conversational storytelling.
Broadcast TV (Local)	Local credibility, community ties, and relevance to hometown audiences.	Local outlets want voices who can connect issues to the community directly.
Broadcast TV (National)	Big-picture insights, ability to explain why a story matters nationwide.	National hits seek authoritative, confident experts who bring clarity to broader debates.
Live Stage (Festival/Summit)	Charisma, public speaking ability, and readiness to engage in dialogue with panelists or audiences.	Organizers want memorable voices who can carry a room and spark conversation.

Sample One-Liner Pitches

"I can break down today's Supreme Court decision in three key takeaways."

"I'd love to walk listeners through how I reported on this investigative series for three years and what it reveals about American culture."

"I can put this niche fintech story in context for a national audience—why it matters beyond the headlines."

"As a DC-based reporter, I can explain how this housing policy impacts local renters."

"I translate complex topics into stories people connect with—and bring that energy to the stage."



Crafting a Pitch That **Pops**

Subject lines are headlines: 6-8 words max, actionable, intriguing

→ **Good**

"New Data Reveals Surprising Gen Z Spending Habits"

→ **Needs better framing**

"New report available now"

→ **Too Long**

"Interview Opportunity: New findings in report on Gen Z spending practices"

Beyond the Inbox: Smarter Ways to Connect

Email (the standard)

Professional & searchable
Best for formal introductions or
sharing links

DMs (Twitter, Instagram, LinkedIn)

Direct, personal, and often
faster
Great for starting a
conversation or following up

In-Person Networking

Panels, festivals, conferences,
community events
Build trust face-to-face →
memorable impression

Text/WhatsApp (*when invited*)

Quick coordination once a
relationship is built

Legacy media preferences:

Relationship-driven
pitching, subject matter
depth

Tip

Don't wait till your big announcement to begin seeding relationships.



Pitching New Media

Podcasts, Substack, Influencers:

When booking new media, be precise about what they're looking for:

- ➔ **Substack writers:** Seek analysis, not announcements
- ➔ **Podcasters:** Look for compelling, conversational voices
- ➔ **Influencers/bloggers:** Prioritize authenticity, exclusives, visuals

Exclusivity & Insight – Your Secret Weapons

- Give a reporter *something only they get*:
 - Advanced access to data or interviews
 - Regional spin, exclusive quote, embargoed news
- Position your pitch as a **solution to a beat**:
 - “I noticed you covered [X]—here’s what’s next”



Tip

When thinking through exclusivity, how can you create smaller, more targeted offers to segmented outlets or media formats

BROADCAST TIPS

- **SOUND GOOD** We are in the era of the soundbite, so we don't want anything to be left up to interpretation. Avoid pronouns, restating the question in your response and speaking in complete sentences (subject, verb, predicate) instead. Answers should be clear and concise, lead with the headline, and follow up with supporting points (examples, anecdotes, stats). This is your interview, use it to get your messages out.
- **LOOK GOOD** Your demeanor is the strongest message. Always maintain eye contact when responding to questions. Be expressive – make sure your body and face match your words. Be engaging and aware of hand and body movements.
- **FEEL GOOD** Remember, this is your interview. Make sure you have enough time to prep, give yourself time to check for any breaking news, and have energy and confidence when speaking about the work you are doing.

RADIO TIPS

- **SOUND GOOD** Podcasts and radio stations love their clean, crisp audio. Make sure you're in a quiet space and have built in time to check your connection, especially if you must download a new-to-you link like Riverside or ReportIT. For the best audio quality some find that a sitting in small closet or underneath a blanket can help dampen surrounding noise – like a fan – and help the interviewer get crisp sound on their end as well.
- **HEAR GOOD** Make sure you have a backup set of headphones or can listen in an area on speaker should your initial connection be interrupted
- **FEEL GOOD** Make sure to have water near you, since this interview hinges on how you sound you want to be kind to your voice!

**Know your
goals and
objectives
going into the
interview:**

What can we gain
from this media
interaction?

What do I want the
readers/audience
to walk away
remembering?

What do
I want the
headline
to be?

What are the risks
in doing the
interview?

And in not doing
the interview?

Am I the right
person to
do the interview?

Am I prepared
enough,
or do
I have time
to prepare
enough, to do the
interview well?

For Successful Interviews

- **Do** prepare before the interview and understand what you want out of it as a win
- **Do** speak to facts, not to feelings
- **Do** be transparent and approachable

- **Don't** get bogged down in jargon or technical details
- **Don't** answer questions that are leading, hypothetical or based on a faulty premise
- **Don't** let them see you sweat; we're always happy and engaged throughout an interview

Lead with the
Headline



Supporting
Details

How to frame an interview:

- ❖ What do you want your audience to know?
- ❖ How would you talk to your friends and family about this subject?

Learning the bridge: It's as easy as your ABCs

1. **A**ddress the question briefly
2. **B**ridge to your key message
3. **C**onclude by telling them what the facts mean and why it matters



“Thank you for asking, I haven’t seen this in my reporting, however we have seen...”

“I’ve had sources frame that differently...”

“Good question. I haven’t come across that in my work... What I can tell you is...”

**Flag What's
Important**

**You're the expert –
Tell your audience
what they
need to know**

“If there's one thought
I can leave you with,
it's this...”

”We've talked about many issues. It
boils down to these 3 important
points...”

Always Recap Key Points at the End of the Interview

Reporters typically ask:

Is there anything you would like to add or anything I missed?

- Cement your authority on a subject
 - “I’ve covered this for XX years/elections/olympics and never seen this”
- Repeat key point(s)
- Use opportunity to cover something that didn't come up
- Go back to an area that you think the reporter didn't follow

If they don't ask, use the chance to bridge back to key points: “Before we go/hang up I want to emphasize...”

ENGAGE, DON'T EVADE

Avoid appearing defensive

Remain calm

Be aware challenging narratives or
themes

COMMON ATTACKS AND RESPONSES

Words in mouth

“I wouldn’t put it that way...”

Inaccurate fact or allegation

Feel empowered to correct it

Multiple questions

Pick the question that best
bridges back to your talking
points

Five ways to ACE an Interview

1

PAINT A PICTURE

Set your agenda and 3 key messages with proof points:

- Research, statistics, facts
- Relatable examples, anecdotes or person experience

2

LEARN THE BRIDGE

Every question is an opportunity to deliver your message:

- “What’s really important is...”
- “The reason we’re here today is...”
- “Our primary focus is...”
- “I am glad you mentioned that because...”
- “The facts show that...”

3

STAY OUT OF TROUBLE

You are always on the record:

- Correct false statements immediately
- Don’t take tough questions personally
- If you start to stray, stop and rephrase
- If you don’t understand the question, say so

4

NEVER SAY NO COMMENT

You may decline to reveal details, but always with a reason:

- Legal or proprietary
- Hypothetical/ Glass ball situations
- Unfamiliar statistics, comments, studies or surveys
- Personal opinion

5

PROJECT POSITIVE ENERGY

Show excitement about your work and key messages:

- Be aware of body language, tone
- Don’t repeat a negative
- Frame your reply as a positive
- Asked about challenges? Talk solutions!

Thank You!

Questions?